

SKILLS NOTEBOOK — ACADEMIC ENGLISH I

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The Grammar of Honest Writing

What Academic English I taught me about citing, paraphrasing, and reading with purpose

GEF1101: Academic English I

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Portfolio note

I took Academic English I in my first semester at ULAB (Fall 2023). I already knew, in broad terms, what academic writing involved — I had a BA in English from the University of Dhaka. What the course gave me was not the concepts but the practice: summarising techniques drilled and tested, referencing learned as a physical habit rather than a theoretical idea, and the structured repetition that turned knowledge into competence. More importantly, it gave me a mentor. The course instructor, Iram Mehrin, became a guide I have relied on throughout my undergraduate years, and the relationship that began in this classroom has shaped my academic trajectory in ways no single course could. Two years later, ULAB's Centre for Language Studies hired me as an Instructor of Academic English. This notebook reflects on the skills the course built and the mentorship it started.

What the course gave me that I did not already have

I did not arrive at ULAB unfamiliar with academic writing. Four years of reading and writing at the University of Dhaka's English department had given me fluency, a feel for argument, and a rough sense of how citation and referencing work. What I lacked was not the idea but the discipline. I knew, abstractly, that a paraphrase should preserve meaning while changing structure. I had never been made to do it under timed conditions, receive feedback on where my version drifted from the original, and do it again. I knew that references follow a format. I had never been drilled on APA style until the formatting became automatic rather than something I had to look up each time. Academic English I closed that gap. It took skills I understood in principle and turned them into skills I could perform under pressure, which is the difference that matters when the rest of the degree depends on them.

The course also did something no syllabus can fully describe: it introduced me to Iram Mehrin, the course instructor, who became my mentor for the rest of my undergraduate years. Mentorship is difficult to specify in a skills notebook because it operates across semesters rather than within one, but the relationship that began in this

course has been, looking back, at least as consequential as the skills themselves. She guided me through the transition from a student who could write to a student who could research, and when I began developing a proposal on generative AI and critical writing in Bangladeshi higher education, she became the supervisor for that project. The course was a semester long; the mentorship it produced has lasted three years and counting.

Summarising: the skill the course built through repetition

Summarising was the skill the course spent the most structured time on, and the one where the gap between knowing and doing was widest for me. I could summarise informally — any reader can produce a rough account of what a text says. What I could not do reliably, before this course drilled it, was produce a summary that was accurate to the source's argument, proportional to its emphasis, free of my own interpretation, and properly attributed. Each of those requirements sounds simple; meeting all four at once, under test conditions, is a different exercise entirely.

The course taught summarising as a technique with steps: identify the source's main claim, note the key supporting points, restate both in your own words without adding evaluation, and cite. The steps are mechanical, which is the point — a mechanical process can be practised until it becomes reliable, whereas an intuitive sense of “what the text was about” is unreliable precisely because it mixes the source's argument with the reader's reaction to it. What I carry from this training into my own teaching is the insistence on separating summary from response: first show that you understand what the author said, then say what you think about it. Students who skip the first step produce opinions without demonstrated comprehension, which is the most common writing failure I encounter in my Academic English classes now.

Why we cite: the reason behind the rule

Citation was the part of the course I resisted most at first, because I came from a literary-studies background where citation conventions were lighter and the emphasis was on interpretation rather than evidence chains. Academic English I reframed citation for me not as a formatting requirement but as an ethical and epistemic practice. We cite to acknowledge intellectual debt, to let the reader verify the claim, and to locate our argument within a conversation that preceded us. Each of these is a reason, not a rule, and the distinction matters: a student who treats citation as a rule will format correctly and still plagiarise by accident, because rules can be followed mechanically. A student who understands the reasons will cite properly even in unfamiliar formats, because they know what the citation is doing.

The course distinguished in-text citation from the reference list and taught both APA conventions. What I found most valuable, and what I now emphasise when teaching, is the logic connecting the two: the in-text citation is a pointer (author, date) that lets the reader locate the full source in the reference list, and the reference list entry contains exactly the information needed to find the original document. When students understand the system as a lookup mechanism rather than a decoration, they stop making the most common errors — citing in-text without a reference entry, or listing references they never actually cited. The system is designed to be complete and cross-referenced, and once you see that design, the formatting becomes obvious rather than arbitrary.

Referencing: precision as a practice

Referencing was where precision stopped being abstract and became a physical habit. The course taught APA style specifically — author-date for in-text, full bibliographic entry in the references — and I remember finding the rules tedious until a

small moment clarified them. I had cited a source as “(Smith, 2019)” in-text but listed it as “Smith, J. (2020)” in the reference list because I had confused the publication year with the access year. The mismatch meant the reader could not follow the pointer, which meant the citation did not do its job. That single error taught me more about why referencing formats exist than any lecture could have: the point is that the in-text marker and the reference entry must match exactly, because the system breaks the moment they do not.

Now, teaching the same material, I find that the most persistent student error is not formatting but completeness — students who cite in their paragraphs but forget to build the reference list, or who assemble a reference list from sources they browsed but never actually used in the essay. Both failures break the lookup mechanism. I teach referencing now as a two-way street: every in-text citation must have a matching reference entry, and every reference entry must correspond to an in-text citation. If either direction fails, the system is broken.

Skimming, scanning, and learning to read with a question

Before this course, I read linearly — start at the beginning, finish at the end. Academic English I introduced skimming and scanning as distinct reading strategies, and the distinction changed how I work with texts. Skimming is reading for the overall shape of an argument: the abstract, the introduction, the first sentence of each paragraph, and the conclusion. Scanning is searching for a specific piece of information: a date, a name, a statistic, a definition. The two serve different purposes, and the course’s most useful lesson was that academic reading almost never starts with close reading. It starts with skimming to decide whether the text is relevant, then scanning to locate the specific material you need, and only then close reading of the passages that matter.

This sounds simple, but it solved a problem I did not know I had. As an English graduate trained in literary close reading, I had been reading every academic article the

way I read a novel — slowly, from start to finish, attending to every sentence. That approach is appropriate for a poem; it is wildly inefficient for a twenty-page empirical study where only three paragraphs bear on your research question. The course gave me permission to read strategically rather than reverently, and that permission is one of the most practically useful things I learned at ULAB. I now teach it on the first day as a way of telling new students that academic reading is not about respect for the text; it is about extracting what you need from it efficiently and honestly.

Paragraph structure: the unit of academic argument

The course taught the standard model of the academic paragraph: a topic sentence that states the paragraph's claim, supporting sentences that develop it with evidence or reasoning, and a concluding sentence that either summarises or transitions. The model is useful because it is a scaffold — it gives a beginning writer a structure to fill, which is easier than writing into open space. But the deeper lesson, which I only fully understood later, is that the paragraph is the unit of argument in academic writing, not the sentence and not the essay. Each paragraph makes one claim and supports it; the essay is a sequence of paragraphs whose claims build on each other. Once you see that, outlining becomes a matter of listing your claims in order and checking whether each one follows from the last.

The gap between knowing this and doing it is where most of my students struggle, and where I struggled too. The most common failure mode is the paragraph that contains multiple unrelated claims — a sign that the writer has not yet decided what the paragraph is about. The second most common is the paragraph that states a claim but never supports it, relying on the reader to take the assertion on trust. The course's paragraph exercises trained me out of both habits, and I now use similar exercises in my own classes, because the paragraph is small enough to practise in a single session and important enough to carry the weight of the whole course.

The foundation and the mentor

A foundational course is easy to undervalue once you have moved past it. The skills Academic English I built are now so embedded in my daily work that I rarely think about where I learned them. But they were learned, not innate, and they were learned here, in a course that valued repetition and testing over novelty, because foundational skills are built through practice rather than inspiration.

The mentorship is harder to summarise in a notebook, because it did not follow a syllabus. Iram Mehrin saw something in the way I engaged with the material and offered guidance that extended well beyond the semester. Over the next three years she helped me navigate the gap between being a student who writes well and being a researcher who thinks carefully — a gap that no single course can close but that a sustained mentoring relationship can bridge. When I began working on a research proposal about generative AI and the erosion of critical writing among Bangladeshi undergraduates, she became the supervisor for that project, which means the intellectual relationship that started in Academic English I is now producing the research I will carry into graduate applications. The course set me up for the rest of the degree. The mentor it gave me set me up for the rest of the career.